

The Glorious Great Tantra of the Vajra King

Śrī Vajrarāja Mahātantra · Toh 403 · Derge Kangyur

དཔལ་རྡོ་རྒྱལ་པོའི་རྒྱུད་ཅན་པོ་

The Glorious Tantra of the Great Vajra King, known in Sanskrit as the Śrī Vajrarāja Mahātantra and in Tibetan as Dpal rdo rje rgyal po'i rgyud chen po, is a Buddhist tantric scripture belonging to the class of Vajrayāna canonical texts. Set within a celestial assembly of heroes and ḍākinīs, the tantra opens with Vajrahṛdaya and other attendants posing questions to the Blessed One about the nature of the vajra, the tantra, and the king, framing the text as a revelation of esoteric doctrine concerning the inseparability of body, speech, and mind of all Tathāgatas. The work is associated with charnel ground symbolism and the ornamental or transformative dimensions of tantric practice. It is Toh 403 in the Kangyur, where it is classed among the tantric texts, and was translated into Tibetan by the paṇḍita Gayadhara and the monk-translator Śākya Yeshe.

The Tantra King of the Charnel Ground Ornament is complete. It was translated by the paṇḍita Gayadhara and the translator, the monk Śākya Yeshe.

In Sanskrit: Śrī Vajrarāja Mahātantra. In Tibetan: The Glorious Tantra of the Great Vajra King. Homage to the Glorious King of Vows.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, together with the innumerable heroes and ḍākinīs headed by Vajrahṛdaya, dwelling within the bhaga of the vajra lady who is the body, speech, and mind of all Tathāgatas, was honored with the outer, inner, secret, and unsurpassed supreme offering. Then, drawing near to the Blessed One, and the Blessed One having smiled, Vajrahṛdaya and the others made this request in verse:

What is the great vajra? What is the tantra? What is the king?

The Blessed One declared:

The vajra of meaning has four aspects,
known as the number of the four empowerments.
It is called vajra because it destroys conceptuality,
and it has four forms:
outer, inner, secret, and utterly secret —
three-pointed, single-pointed, and five-pointed,
and nine-pointed — these are what it is.

Twelve-pointed — that too is vajra.
These are the four vajras of symbol.

The non-dual, single-pointed vajra
abandons all conceptual thought.
The three-pointed vajra is body, speech, and mind,
taught in order to destroy
attachment, aversion, and delusion.
The five-pointed vajra is the symbol of the five wisdoms:
mirror-like, equality, discerning,
all-accomplishing, and dharmadhātu wisdom —
it destroys the five afflictions:
aversion, pride, attachment,
envy, and delusion.

As for the nine-pointed vajra,
it is taught as the nine wisdoms,
destroying the nine grounds of the three realms —
the desire realm, the form realm, and the formless realm;
the stages of the hearers, the solitary buddhas, the bodhisattvas,
the vidyādhāras, the buddhas, and the great wisdom —
purifying the obscurations that veil each of these nine grounds.
Thus is the nine-pointed vajra taught.

The twelve-pointed vajra
is the twelve wisdoms that abandon
the twelve links of dependent origination of saṃsāra.
From ignorance arise formations;
through the condition of formations arises consciousness;
then name-and-form and the six sense bases,
contact, feeling, craving, grasping,
becoming, birth, and aging-and-death.
The antidote that abandons all these
is the actualization of dharma-wisdom.

From that arise the six wisdoms by nature.
From that arise the essence of body, speech, and mind.
From that arise the six sense bases as buddhas.
From that arises non-dual contact.

From that arises the experience of great bliss.
Self-knowing suchness is craving,
and taking up is what reveals all phenomena.
Becoming is the saṃbhogakāya (enjoyment body).
Birth is taught as the nirmāṇakāya (emanation body).
Aging, death, the continuum, and nirvāṇa
dissolve into the expanse of luminous great emptiness.

Therefore the twelve-pointed vajra
constitutes the four vajras of substance:
penetrating, sharp, and three-edged —
by grinding substances with its four sides
it makes them smooth and clear, destroying them.
With its round face it destroys roughness.
With its five edges it accomplishes all as desired.

Then the great meaning is taught:
object of meditation, intention, conduct,
vows, diligence, aspiration,
and likewise the great wisdom —
to each of these, seven by seven are joined.
Therefore it is taught as "the Great."

The tantra has five aspects:
outer, inner, secret,
utterly secret, and the great secret.
These, as they abide in continual flow,
are taught as the tantra of cause —
the full realization of their meaning as it is
is taught as the tantra of result.
The tantra of cause and result are non-dual;
the cause is the non-dual,
self-knowing wisdom that is ultimate —
the ultimate, unsurpassed tantra.

The king also has five aspects:
outer, inner, secret, utterly secret,
and the supremely great secret.
With respect to their meaning: empowerment,

To overcome the adversarial forces belonging to each,
the king is therefore taught in five aspects.

Vajrahṛdaya then asked again:

"How is the Blessed One to be understood?

How are the body, speech, and mind
of all the Tathāgatas to be understood?

How is the consort's bhaga to be understood?

What is the vajra, and what is the essence?

What are the heroes, and what are the ḍākinīs?

How is the immeasurable to be understood?

How is 'abiding in union' to be understood?

How is 'having made offering' — outer, inner, secret,
and unsurpassed — to be understood?

How is 'arrayed in the manifest direction' to be understood?

How is 'smiling' to be understood?

How is 'gazing' to be understood?"

The Blessed One declared:

"Afflictions (kleśas), the māra of the lord of death,
the māra of the aggregates, and the māra of the gods —
by vanquishing these four māras, one is the Vanquisher.

Because of being endowed, possessing six qualities —
sovereignty, fine form,

glory, renown, good fortune,
and an abundance of wisdom —

one who possesses those six is called the Endowed One.

The phenomena of saṃsāra are sorrow;

having been freed from them in just that way, one is the Transcended.

All Tathāgatas who have transcended

act for the welfare of beings — thus, Tathāgata.

Together with the essential nature of the body, speech, and mind
of the buddhas of all three times,

what is called 'the consort' is the dharmadhātu, the basic space of
phenomena;

because everything arises from that, it is bhaga;

it is said to abide inseparably therein.

Vajra: the phenomena of the Dharma are greatly fearsome.

Essence: great wisdom.

And so forth — these have many meanings.

What is called 'hero': there are five aspects —
outer, inner, secret, and the rest.

It is in order to overcome conceptual thought that they exist.

Moving through space, one is a *ḍākinī*;

it should also be understood with respect to the channels and so forth.

Because everything arises from her,

I have spoken of her as 'mother.'

Since the meaning thereof is beyond measure,

for that reason she is called immeasurable.

As for 'abiding in union':

because suchness is inseparable from its meaning,

this is explained as being of a single import;

it is not twofold, and in that moment

it is neither outer nor inner.

Now, the outer offering is to be explained:

flowers, incense, lamps,

perfume, divine food, drink,

music and melodious song,

grace, laughter and dance,

horses, elephants, jewels, and so forth.

Then, the inner offering:

with the *bhaga* clasped and the breast pressed,

with the five nectars and the five drinks,

united with *bodhicitta*,

offer through the aggregates, the elements, the sense bases,

and so forth.

Then, the secret offering:

channels, winds (*prāṇas*), and *bindus* —

through those very channels, winds, and *bindus*,

by means of non-dual bliss,

make the offering.

Then, the utterly secret offering:

the first joy, the supreme joy,

joy without joy, and likewise the co-emergent joy —
through those distinctions of bliss, through suchness itself,
offer through the joy of one's own nature and all the rest.

Then, through the unsurpassed offering:
by realizing self-knowing awareness as empty,
the clear light of suchness is the dharmakāya —
that very suchness is the supreme, unsurpassed offering."

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, Vajrahṛdaya and the other members of the assembly were filled with delight and gladness, and they rejoiced. They circumambulated to the left, and through their individual miraculous powers they vanished from sight.

The glorious Cakrasaṃvara Vajra King Tantra is complete.

Translated by the yoginī Candramālā and the translator, the fully ordained monk Śākyayes hes.

Translator's Notes

- The passage opens with a colophon closing one tantra and then immediately begins a new text, the Śrī Vajrarāja Mahātantra. The two texts are adjacent in the canon and the colophon of the first runs directly into the title and opening of the second, as rendered above.

The phrase "bhaga of the vajra lady who is the body, speech, and mind of all Tathāgatas" follows tantric symbolic idiom closely. The Blessed One abides in the bhaga — the Sanskrit term retained here as a technical tantric term for the consort's womb or sacred space — of the vajra lady, meaning he rests in union with the wisdom consort who embodies all tathāgata body, speech, and mind. This is standard Anuttarayoga framing.

The passage ends mid-sentence; the source text is cut off at that point.

The enumeration of nine grounds correlated with the nine-pointed vajra is somewhat compressed and the exact referents of "vidyādhara stages" and "great wisdom" as stages alongside the standard bodhisattva grounds deserve note: the text appears to treat the three realms as yielding nine divisions that map onto hearers, solitary buddhas, bodhisattva stages, vidyādhara levels, and buddha gnosis, but the precise scheme is not unpacked further in this excerpt.

- The colophon names the translators as Candramālā, identified as a yoginī, and the lotsāwa Śākyayeśes, a monk. This is the standard closing colophon form for a canonical Tibetan translation.

The term bhaga, left untranslated throughout in keeping with the preceding passage's established convention, carries both its literal Sanskrit sense of "source" or "womb" and its technical tantric valence as a symbol for the dharmadhātu. The text itself glosses it this way.

The five joys enumerated in the utterly secret offering correspond to the standard Cakrasaṃvara and Hevajra tantric schema of the four joys plus a fifth; the rendering "joy without joy" for dga' bral follows the standard commentarial reading of that term as pointing beyond joy itself.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.